

Assignment: Paper Presentations

Ph.D. Environment and Development Economics

UMN Department of Applied Economics

Instructor: Raahil Madhok

2026-09-15

1 Overview

The goal of this assignment is threefold: (i) to teach you how to read economics papers quickly, (ii) to teach you how to talk casually about papers you have read, and (iii) to prepare you for presenting at economics conferences. As you proceed through your PhD, and then into your careers, you will inevitably have to do all three of these things many times. We will focus not just on content, but also public speaking skills, slide preparation, content organization, and delivery.

2 Structure

One randomly-selected student will present a pre-assigned paper at the beginning of each lecture. All students will read **the same** paper, which can be found in the syllabus (highlighted in red). The selection procedure is as follows:

1. **Slides:** Before each lecture, you will each read the assigned paper and prepare **10 slides** summarizing the paper. You may make your slides in groups. These slides will be uploaded to Canvas. All students are required to submit summary slides each week regardless of whether you are chosen to present. You may use AI to assist you in making your slides.
2. **The hat:** At the beginning of each lecture, I will put all your names in a hat.
3. **Randomization:** I will select a student to present randomly **without replacement**. This means that once you present, you are taken out of the pool. But you still need to submit summary slides even after you present
4. **Presentation:** You will give a 10-minute presentation of the paper, with 5 minutes for Q&A. Presentation tips can be found below.

3 Presentation Tips

Many of these tips were provided by Trudy Cameron to help students prepare for AERE sessions. Here is an example of a recent presentation I gave (15 minutes/15 slides) that follows these tips.

- Each presentation should have 10 slides (fewer is okay, but not more).
- Allocate about 1 minute per slide.
- It helps to rehearse a couple of times to ensure that the presentation fits within the allotted time. It is considered poor form at conferences to exceed your time.
- Do not present every detail. Your job is to summarize the paper and entice people to read the full paper.
- Start your presentation with a single slide that succinctly summarizes the research question, setting, data, empirical strategy, and two key results. This previews the whole paper, and the rest of the presentation should elaborate on each point.

- Use one-line bullet points when possible. Eye-tracking to a new line can interfere with quickly grasping a point. Avoid leaving a single word on a wrapped line. Remove superfluous words.
- Since you only have 10 minutes, do not spend too much time on the literature review. Instead, explain how the paper improves upon the existing literature (i.e., its contributions), while still including citations.
- Aim to show only one equation. Try to talk “about” the equation rather than provide a detailed explanation of every term. You want to bring along the median audience member, not just dazzle the most sophisticated theorist or econometrician in the room.
- Try not to read your slides directly. The audience can read. The bullet points should guide what you say, which means rehearsal is important. Think carefully about how you will transition between slides.

4 Rubric

Criteria	Exemplary	Proficient	Adequate	Needs Improvement	Score
1. Content (20 pts)	Presentation is well-organized and provides a clear, concise summary of the research question, setting, data, empirical strategy, and key results.	Presentation covers most key aspects of the research but lacks some detail or clarity.	Presentation covers the basic elements of the research but is incomplete or unclear in important places.	Key components of the research are missing, inaccurate, or poorly presented.	/20
2. Slide Design & Visuals (15 pts)	Slides are clear, concise, visually appealing, and easy to follow. Figures, tables, equations, and other visuals are used effectively to communicate key ideas.	Slides are generally clear and effective but have minor issues with organization, readability, or visual presentation.	Slides are functional but are sometimes cluttered, overly detailed, or difficult to follow.	Slides are difficult to follow, overcrowded, or poorly designed, and visuals do not effectively communicate the research.	/15
3. Time Management (10 pts)	Presentation stays within the 10-minute limit and allocates time effectively across the paper's main components.	Presentation is slightly over or under time but still covers the key points effectively.	Presentation is noticeably over or under time, causing some material to be rushed or omitted.	Presentation is substantially over or under time, resulting in incomplete or poorly covered material.	/10
4. Clarity & Communication (15 pts)	Speaker explains the research clearly and confidently, avoids unnecessary jargon, and transitions smoothly between ideas and slides.	Communication is generally clear, but some explanations or transitions could be sharper.	Communication is uneven or unclear at times, and the speaker relies heavily on reading from the slides.	Presentation is difficult to follow, disorganized, or communicated unclearly.	/15
5. Understanding & Analysis (20 pts)	Presentation demonstrates a strong understanding of the paper's motivation, empirical strategy, results, and contribution. Speaker clearly explains why the research matters and appropriately interprets the findings.	Presentation demonstrates solid understanding but lacks depth in explaining the empirical strategy, results, or contribution.	Presentation demonstrates a basic understanding but misses important nuances or has difficulty interpreting the research.	Presentation demonstrates limited understanding of the paper or substantially misinterprets its methods, findings, or contribution.	/20
6. Audience Engagement & Q&A (10 pts)	Speaker maintains audience attention and responds clearly and thoughtfully to questions.	Speaker generally engages the audience and provides reasonable responses to questions.	Audience engagement is limited, or responses to questions reveal some uncertainty about the paper.	Speaker has difficulty engaging the audience or responding to questions about the paper.	/10
7. Professionalism & Preparation (10 pts)	Presentation is polished, well-rehearsed, and professional. Speaker is clearly prepared and does not rely heavily on reading slides.	Presentation is generally professional and prepared, with minor issues in delivery or polish.	Presentation shows some preparation but feels under-rehearsed or overly dependent on the slides.	Presentation appears poorly prepared, unrehearsed, or disorganized.	/10
Total Score	Total				/100